

Music, by George!

Meet India's music man, **Chris George**, of the EasyBuyMusic fame. This young CEO, who believes a lot in the potential of online music in India, dares to win

VIDYARAMANAN S.

What would optimism be if it walked on two legs? The answer, at least in the music industry in India, would be Chris George. He's the CEO of EasyBuyMusic. The man who walked down the dotcom graveyard after the recent crash and built an entire portal for music aficionados in India.

At a time when hundreds of dotcom ventures with flailing arms and drenched enthusiasm were shutting shop, George stepped into the music market with guts and determination. And working on his unfailing belief that "Who dares wins!" he took charge of his online music store, www.easybuymusic.com.



Chris George, CEO,
EasyBuyMusic

"A buyer will buy music if it's good and not bother with the record label"

George completed his B.Sc in India before heading to the New York University to earn an MBA. He became an understudy to the head of the Department of Business and Entrepreneurial Studies of the university and even set up the Young Business Entrepreneurs Society. For inspiration, he doesn't look further than the Virgin CEO Richard Branson who he thinks is the perfect amalgamation of fun and work.

George started his career with Sprint PCS and later moved to Bell Atlantic where he successfully handled its value-added services division. When his father hinted at his returning to India, George readily agreed. Mumbai had a promising market and where he felt he could gainfully employ his knowledge and experience. He honed his skills handling his family busi-

nesses and soon decided to carve out a career in the music industry.

He had started an event management and promotion company called Danzig Corp. during his college days in India. His company handled some events like the Bryan Adams concert and the Lakme Maximum Rampwalk. Thereafter, George, along with Shantanu Roy Ghosh, a childhood friend and partner at Danzig Corp., came up with the concept of getting music across to music lovers whenever they want it, from wherever they want it.

The concept was sold to Times Music and it saw musical light in the form of 'Dial M for Music', a successful exercise. It later evolved into a new business model executed via EasyBuyMusic, now India's largest online music store.

Now, when he talks about the competition in the music market, he grins and says "music is always easy to sell". And continues: "The band is always the brand. A buyer will buy music if it's good and not bother with the record label. Consumers want a general purpose aggregator."

A buyer who buys music cassettes and CDs from a certain place, EasyBuyMusic for instance, will come to the same familiar place to buy and download music when digital download gains momentum. This is how George believes the firm will sustain itself in the long run.

EasyBuyMusic has developed one of the best of the supply chain management (SCM) methodologies driving its e-commerce engine, which other companies like Rediff have implemented too. Many firms have the technology but not the right distribution platform and George aims to provide assistance to such companies to help them fare better in the online market.

Although the Internet is currently only one of the channels through which revenue is being generated, the rest of the revenue accrues through orders placed via phone calls on their toll free number.

George also believes that buying over the Web will soon increase, leading to greater sales and success for EasyBuyMusic. And though India is a difficult market, it is not an impossible one to capture—he has faith that will sustain.

For how long, the market and his determination will tell. ■